



A JOB, FINALLY: BPSC planning to clear the five-year backlog in one go
Subhani, "We are short of at least 700 officers in the state civil service rank alone. This is a serious problem."

Subhani, however, disagrees with the argument that older officers would be less motivated to take up the operational jobs. "It is perfectly okay if someone is picked on merit," he says. The merit argument stands a bit diluted considering a significantly lower mark yardstick for clearing the preliminary test. A general category candidate would require only 40 per cent marks to qualify the entrance test. Similarly, the women and the SC/ST candidates would have to score 32 per cent while those belonging to OBC and extremely backward castes are required to secure 36.5 and 34 per cent marks, respectively, to clear the prelims.

Many believe that the relatively less stringent eligibility criterion would attract a large number of aspirants. This is also what BPSC requires in order to tide over the crisis of officers. The shortage of deputy collectors has forced the government to entrust almost 500 block development officers with multiple jobs. They have been asked to function as circle officers also. This, however, has not helped much due to a huge backlog in both the offices. "This is because nobody wants to take up two fulltime responsibilities. Similarly, there is a huge shortage of executive magistrates at the district level which impedes administrative functioning," said a senior IAS officer. Bihar runs with almost half the required strength of state administrative service officers. Worse still, it is equally short of IAS officers. The shortage is one major reason why the state is at the bottom on many parameters.

Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Modi has admitted that the implementation machinery is the weakest link that the Government is now negotiating with. Acknowledges a senior IAS officer: "At the implementation level, there is a clear disconnect between those who are entrusted with execution and those who frame policies." But for now, life awaits some at 40. **by Amitabh Srivastava**

Mid-life Bonanza

By raising the upper age limit for civil service exams to 40, the state plans to compensate the deprived and tackle the crisis of officers

You see the sweetest things in life grow sweeter as the years roll on... Life begins at forty," sang Sophie Tucker in *Life begins at forty*. That may well become the anthem of job-seekers in Bihar, especially after the Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) raised the maximum age limit to 40 years for aspirants who would take the combined entrance test on February 24, next year.

The test will be held for recruitment to the 14 cadres that include state civil and police services. Further age relaxations have been offered to those who are already in service or those who belong to the reserved categories. Now, there are bright chances of one seeing a 40-year-old deputy collector undergoing probation, or someone donning the cap of deputy superintendent of police at 42. These exams will also choose candidates for jobs that entail operational needs, like in excise, police and prison services, where a 40-plus may not have optimum physical motivation to execute the task at hand.

This is unusual because in most

states the upper age limit for public service jobs is 35. Outwardly, the BPSC age relaxation offer may appear extraordinary. But it makes sense considering the fact that no recruitment tests were conducted during the last five years. BPSC had failed to hold tests due to a string of controversies that saw a number of its officials facing corruption charges, besides postponement and rescheduling of the tests. The government is now compensating those aspirants who had not got a chance to compete all these years. The BPSC mandarins have been mired in controversies and as many as three of its chairmen were arrested and sent to judicial custody in the past decade.

It is not only the aspirants who have suffered but the state government has also been left with a greying bureaucracy. The average age of state administrative service officers is 45. This is perhaps why BPSC has decided to simultaneously conduct preliminary tests for five pending batches as it wants to clear the backlog in one go. Agrees Bihar Personnel Secretary Amir

"Bihar lacks 700 officers in state civil service rank alone."

AMIR SUBHANI, PERSONNEL SECRETARY, BIHAR